ing votes citing the "delivering on poll promises of 2023" and using its tried-and-tested Hindutva and "Christian conversion" cards to reach out to voters. The killing of a Yadav youth in Chhattisgarh, allegedly by Muslims, ahead of the consecration of the Balak Ram idol at the Ram mandir in Ayodhya in January, is being repeatedly revisited, especially on social media platforms.

"As far as the state is concerned, the honouring of promises made to the electorate before the assembly election, including procurement of paddy at Rs 3,100 per quintal, payment of bonus of past two years [on paddy procurement], launch of the Mahtari Vandan Yojana [under which Rs 1,000 is paid per month to eligible women], all within 100 days of the Vishnu Deo Sai government taking over, are issues that the BJP is raising. At the national level, the works done by the Modi government in the past 10 years are being highlighted," says Pankaj Jha, media advisor to the Chhattisgarh CM. He further claims: "Conversely, the absence of a credible choice as PM in the Opposition ranks and the corrupt government run by the Congress in the past five years in Chhattisgarh will cost the party dear in the state."

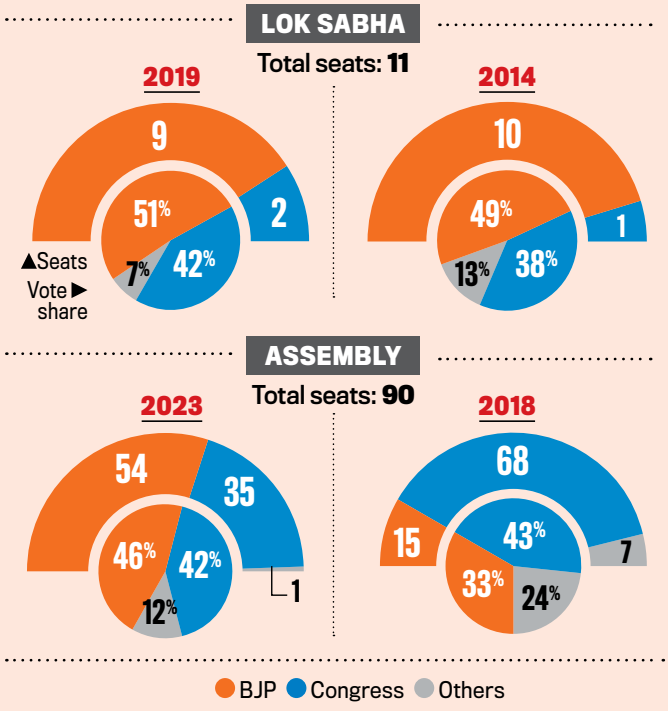
However, the Congress seems intent on taking a page out of the BJP's own book. While ahead of the 2023 election, the BJP had got its cadre to go door-to-door to fill up forms for the proposed Mahtari Vandan Yojana, the Congress is doing the same now for the Rs 1 lakh annual scheme for eligible women announced as part of its 2024 manifesto. "All issues relevant for other states are relevant for Chhattisgarh too. We are raising the failure of the Modi government to provide jobs to the youth, failure on the environmental front, not giving women their due. The promises made by the Congress in its manifesto, especially the Mahalaxmi Scheme under which eligible women would get Rs 1 lakh per year, will be a game-changer," declared Chhattisgarh Congress spokesperson, Sushil Anand Shukla. Despite its confident demeanour, however, the Congress is battling defections in the state—former Bilaspur mayor Vani Rao, former state general secretary Chandrashekar Shukla, sitting Jagdalpur mayor Safira Sahu and Bilaspur district panchayat president Arun Chauhan are among those who have quit the Congress to join the BJP ranks ahead of the election. The Bahujan Samaj Party's two tribal Christian candidates—Innocent Kujur and Sanjay Ekka, fielded from Raigarh and Surguja, respectively—are also likely to cut into the Congress vote bank in these seats, with political observers hinting at a possible tacit understanding between the BJP and the BSP.

As a senior BJP leader told INDIA TODAY, "The BJP has displayed higher political IQ in the state time and again but, looking at the ticket distribution, the Congress has displayed greater EQ [emotional quotient]." Victory would require a balance of both. ■

SAFFRON SPREAD

The Modi wave had ensured victory for the BJP in 2014 and 2019, even though the Congress managed one assembly win in 2018







THE 2023 VERDICT WAS ASCRIBED TO THE BJP'S TACTICAL SKILLS AND FEUDS WITHIN CONGRESS. BHUPESH BAGHEL, IN THE FRAY FROM RAJNANDGAON, WAS A POPULAR CM